

For Xhenis and
Petru, because how
they XPerience
love and life with
fierce beauty and
tender strength
inspires us all

Life often hits us hard.
Routine and stress and
steady erosion shrink us.
Love is growth as
counterweight to life's evil,
but how to feed it? This
game is one for couples
that are not too weary of
a bit of playful work and
wish to level up their
marriage game.

Rule 1

Level up your marriage by talking about the topics on the cards and reaching a common answer. That's it, that is the game!

Rule 2

When talking about a topic, you only level-up when you reach an answer you are both happy with, and one that you both believe is useful to have articulated. You do not level up if you reach two different answers.

Rule 3

Every time you get to have a meaningful conversation about your relationship, congratulate yourselves. Take the card and stick it with some magnet to your fridge, as an achievement.

Rule 4

If you are struggling to pick topics, do it like this. Each pick a color (or the same color). Then draw 3 face-down cards each only from picked colors.

Rock-paper-scissors to decide who goes first. Then the first one picks a topic from their drawn topics.

Rule 5

You only level up if you do it constantly. Every month with no new talk resets your progress. We advice you set for yourself a recurring date, like the first and third Wed of every month.

Rule 6

The cards are kinda cool and you can also use them some other way. Actually, on one of the cards you will find a QR code to a lil piece of software that lets you create more cards that you can then print by following the instructions found at the same link.



Make your own cards.

[github.com/
olaruandreidan/XPCardGame](https://github.com/olaruandreidan/XPCardGame)

What does our
ideal weekday
morning look
like, for both
of us?

How do we
want to spend
the last
twenty
minutes
before sleep?

How do we want
to handle the
laundry, cooking,
and errands split
as our lives get
busier?

How do we want
to handle
differing sleep
schedules or
night-owl versus
early-riser
habits?

What's our rule of thumb for big versus small purchases: who decides, and at what price does it become a “we” decision?

How do we
recover,
practically, after
a
short-tempered
moment at
home?

How do we want
to use a “day off
from each
other” without it
turning into
avoidance?

What's our rule
for screens,
gaming, or
scrolling once
we're both home
for the evening?

What should
we do when
one of us brings
home a mood
the other didn't
sign up for?

What differences in
our temperaments
have quietly turned
out to be good for
us rather than a
problem to fix?

A household runs on a lot of invisible work, such as noticing the empty fridge, the overdue bill, remembering the friend who needs checking on, planning the weekend. How do we want to build that noticing together, rather than leaving the invisible burden mostly in one person's head?

What did money mean in the household you grew up in and how does that history quietly shape how you two talk about money now?

Who and how decides the priorities in the work that you need to get done together, if fixing the door creek is more important than going out or doing groceries, if cleaning the oven and not selecting the vacation destination is how we spend the afternoon?

Who and how decides the level of quality that needs to be reached for work you do together, be it laundry policy, how clean the fridge should be or how to select a present for common friends?

How do we deal with
a situation in which
the other does
something that we
do not like,
especially if we are
in a social setting or
under time pressure?

Children, such a scary, yet playful concept. How are we aligned on this topic, do we want children, how many, and how would we raise them?

How do we want
our children
raised in what
we believe and
value,
practically?

How do we
want to
care for our
parents as
they age?

How do you want to make big career or life decisions together going forward? If one of us gets a call toward a specific vocation or work, how far are we willing to bend our plans to support it?

Where do
we actually
want to be
living in ten
years?

What does retirement look like for us, and do we picture it the same way?

How do we
want to
handle it if our
incomes end
up very
unequal?

What's the
legacy (not
financial, the
actual character
or values) we
want to leave
behind?

What does a
“good failure”
look like for us, a
risk we’d respect
each other for
taking even if it
didn’t work out?

How do we want
to keep choosing
each other on
purpose, decade
after decade,
rather than by
default?

If one of us can access an opportunity, cushion, or resource the other can't, how can we use that difference in a way that feels good to both of us, rather than something either of us feels guilty or resentful about?

When our families' expectations for us don't match, which parts do we want to keep from each, which do we want to let go of, and what do we want to invent together that's entirely ours?

If we believe the other one is pouring effort into a goal that we do not agree with, how do we communicate that and resolve that issue?

Where is one of us stronger than the other, and how do we let that carry us both instead of becoming a source of resentment?

What does love
as sacrifice
actually cost
each of us this
season,
concretely?

What's a
compliment or
form of
affection you
wish I gave
more often?

How has the
other person
changed you
for the better
this year?

What's a small
daily habit of
ours that's
quietly good for
the marriage,
and that we
should protect?

What does
being fully
present with
each other
actually require
us to put down?

What's
something you're
proud of that
you don't think
I've said out loud
recently?

What does
taking up
something hard
“together,”
rather than each
alone, look like
for us right now?

What's one
thing about
how you love
that I should
learn to
receive better?

What's a version
of "I love you",
not the words,
but an action,
that actually
means the most
to you?

Love can either use people up or genuinely empower them; what makes the difference is mutuality. Describe a recent moment that felt like real, mutual, empowering love. What specifically made it feel that way, and how could we create more moments like it?

Real closeness doesn't come from becoming the same person; it comes from staying different and choosing, again and again, to understand each other across that difference. What's a difference between us that you'd rather protect and get curious about than smooth away?

If physical intimacy is something we're always learning together, what's one thing we'd want to get better at as a team?

What skills does each one of us want to build in order to be a better partner and how do you plan on empowering each other in this process?

How do we actually
want to apologize
to each other?
What makes an
apology land
instead of just
ending the
argument?

What does
patience
actually look
like for us, in
practice, on a
bad day?

What's a grudge
either of us might
still be quietly
carrying, and
what would it
take to actually
let it go?

What's
something I do
that you've
never told me
actually
hurts?

How do we
want to
handle it when
we're both
right and both
hurt?

How do we
make sure the
sun doesn't go
down on an
unresolved
fight?

How do we want
to handle
criticism from
each other
without it
turning into
defense?

How do we want
to handle it when
one of us needs
comfort and the
other jumps
straight to fixing
the problem?

If the exact
situation that
caused our worst
fight happened
again tomorrow,
what would each of
us actually do
differently now?

Think about our last
real disagreement.
What helped us find
the words for what
was actually wrong?
How could we
practice that
together next time, on
purpose?

Philosopher Ellie Anderson calls the work of figuring out what you're feeling, and helping your partner do the same, hermeneutic labor. Where does that kind of work already flow easily between us? Where would you like to build more of it, on purpose, together?

What often gets called someone's "intuition" in a relationship is really years of unacknowledged interpretive work, such as noticing, translating, and making sense. Is there a kind of understanding one of us seems to have "naturally"? What would it look like to treat that as a skill we're both building, rather than a trait only one of us has?

Describe a moment that felt more one-sided or draining than empowering. Without assigning blame, what would need to shift in either of us, or in how we relate, for a moment like that to feel mutual instead?

What's one script
about how love or
partnership is
"supposed" to work,
something you
inherited rather than
chose, that you've
had to unlearn
together?

For Xhenis and Petru

With love,
Maria and Andrei



The marriage level-up
game